FOR PARENTS · SUPPORTING YOUR YOUNG PLAYER

EFFORT OVER OUTCOMES

02

The scoreboard isn't the whole story

THE QUICK VERSION

> Kids learn what matters to us by what we ask about. If the first question after every game is "Did you win?", they quickly learn that winning is what you care about. Ask about effort, fun and favourite moments, and they learn that you care about them.

WHAT'S REALLY GOING ON

Young players can't control the score, the referee, the weather or how good the other team is. What they can control is their effort, their attitude and how they respond when things go wrong. When we focus on those things, we build a confidence that lasts far longer than any result on a Saturday morning.

SWAP "DID YOU WIN?" FOR ONE OF THESE

01
Did you have fun?

02
What was your favourite moment?

03
What's something new you tried today?

04
Who played really well on your team?

05
What was the hardest part?

06
What do you want to work on next?

Start with six magic words: "I loved watching you play."

It works after a big win, a heavy loss, or a game where they barely touched the ball. It tells them your support was never about the result.

Success occurs when opportunity meets preparation.

TRY THIS

1 Let them speak first
Give them a few minutes. If they want to talk about the score, they'll bring it up.

2 Notice the specifics
"I saw you sprint back to help in defence" means far more than "Good game."

3 Praise effort in a loss
A loss where they worked hard is worth celebrating. Make sure they hear that.

4 Keep it short
One or two questions is plenty. A post-game debrief can feel like a performance review.

5 Model it yourself
Talk about effort and enjoyment when you watch sport together on TV, too.

SAY THIS, NOT THAT

SAY THIS	NOT THAT
"I loved how you kept going."	~~"Did you win?"~~
"What was your favourite moment?"	~~"How many goals did you score?"~~
"You worked so hard for your team."	~~"You should have scored that one."~~

QUICK SELF-CHECK

- [ ] My first comment after a game isn't about the score
- [ ] I can name one specific thing my child did well today
- [ ] I praise effort just as much after a loss
- [ ] My child looks forward to talking with me after games

Can't tick them all yet? That's normal. Pick one to work on this week.

COACH'S CORNER

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From under-10s to the World Cup, the players who improve fastest are the ones focused on what they can control. Help your child focus there too.

THE FUTURE BALLER TEAM